

THURSDAY

JESUS WELCOMES PEOPLE WITH DISABILITIES

**MEMORY
VERSE**

When you give a feast, invite the poor, the crippled, the lame and the blind. Then you will be blessed, because they cannot pay you back.

Luke 14:13, 14 ICB (The Holy Bible, International Children's Bible® Copyright© 1986, 1988, 1999, 2015 by Thomas Nelson. Used by permission.)

INTRODUCTION

WELCOMING PEOPLE WITH DISABILITIES

Have you ever had a disability, even a temporary one, when you broke an arm or your leg? What was that like? What did people do for you that was unhelpful, and what was most helpful?

Being temporarily limited by a disability can help us to have greater compassion and consideration for people who live with the permanent challenge of a disability or long-term illness.

Jesus wants everybody to be welcome and included in His kingdom of love. He doesn't want anyone to be excluded because of their disability, or because they can't see, hear, or move around easily. Teach your children to be inclusive of children who have different disabilities. Find story books about real children with disabilities and challenges to read to your children. These stories can also help them to be more understanding, compassionate and kind, to those who are experiencing physical, sensory, social, and mental challenges.

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JESUS WELCOMES PEOPLE WITH DISABILITIES

Read together
the story of the
great banquet
Jesus told:
Luke 14

Jesus told a wonderful story about a big celebration!

A king was planning a wonderful feast! He was so happy and so excited! He sat down with his servants to plan the grand occasion. He thought about the dinner menu. He planned all kinds of dishes so that everyone would have something special that they enjoyed eating. If you were the king, what would you serve at a big party?...Mmm! Yummy!

And then he thought about the dessert menu! What are your favorite desserts and which ones would you serve your special guests?...Mmm! Delicious!

When all the wonderful plans were made for the food, the decorations, and the entertainment, the king sat down with his assistant and wrote out dozens of beautiful invitations. He folded them into gold envelopes, sealed them with the royal seal and mailed them to the guests.

The day of the banquet arrived, and everything was perfect. The gardens were full of flowers, white swans were gliding on the lake, and the banquet table was sparkling with silver flatware, crystal glasses and gold-rimmed plates. An orchestra was practicing in the hallway and all the servants were smiling and smartly dressed.

A servant arrived with the mail for the king! Lots of letters! The king loved to hear from his people. He loved to help them when they were struggling, and sometimes he received thank you notes from them... But, when he opened them, he was so sad. Each letter was from one of the special guests, explaining why they couldn't come to the feast. A new car, a recent marriage, an overseas holiday...and some very poor

The king loved to hear from his people. He loved to help them when they were struggling.

excuses, too. As he crossed each name off the guest list, he realized that no one was coming to his wonderful banquet. How would you feel if you were ready to have a party and nobody came?

Then the king had a wonderful idea! He would invite all the people who didn't usually come to parties! He sent his smart servants to search all the roads and back streets to find people who were poor, hungry, sad, or lonely. The king asked them to find those who were blind, deaf, or who couldn't walk. He wanted all the people who were never invited to parties to enjoy his special party!

The servants brought the excited guests to the castle. They showed them the

beautiful gardens and they listened to the lovely music. Then they took them to the banqueting hall and made sure that they were all comfortable and happy. Then the tables were set with fancy dishes and wonderful food for them to eat, and they all sang and laughed together!

Everyone was so happy! But the king was the happiest person of all! Nothing had ever given him greater joy than bringing joy to lonely and hurting people whose needs were usually forgotten. His servants never forgot that day, either, and whenever they met someone who was sad, or poor, or struggling with an illness or a disability, they asked them what they could do to help, so that they could continue to share the king's welcoming love with everyone they met.

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MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

- Draw your favorite feast on a paper plate or circle and write today's Bible verse around the edge.

PRAAYER ACTIVITIES

PRAYING FOR A PERSON WHO LIVES WITH A DISABILITY

- Ask a person with a disability to tell you their prayer requests.
- Pray for them regularly as a family.
- Write or record a prayer for them to listen to or read.

PRAY FOR HEALTH-CARE PROFESSIONALS IN YOUR CHURCH AND COMMUNITY

- Pray for doctors, nurses, physiotherapists, occupational therapists and other hospital staff who work together to help people to live as well as possible with a disability or long-term illness.
- Write a prayer for them inside a handmade greeting card and thank them for the work they do to help heal, rehabilitate, and support people with all kinds of disabilities.

FAMILY ACTIVITIES

THE ONE-HANDED CHALLENGE

- Ask a parent to help you put one of your arms in a fabric sling so that you can't use it. Or put a sock over your hand.
- Try to do some simple tasks with only one hand: eat a meal, get dressed, tidy your room, help with the washing up, do your favorite hobby.
- What did you learn from this experience? What was difficult and what was surprising?
- How would you like people to respond to you, or help you, if you were never able to use one of your hands?

LIVING WITHOUT SIGHT

- Blindfold someone for an hour and be their helper as they do whatever they would usually do in that time.
- You will need to be their eyes by describing things carefully, helping them to move around safely, and helping them to find things and use them carefully.
- What did you learn from this experience? What was difficult and what was surprising?
- How would you like people to respond to you, or help you, if you were never able to see again?

SHARE A FEAST!

- Even though you may not be able to have a great feast like the king in Jesus' parable, why not find a way to invite a person with a disability to your home for a meal, treat them to a meal in their favorite café, or take a meal to eat with them in their home?

HELPING HANDS

- Find a person in your neighborhood or church community who is housebound, or who has difficulties walking, or doing things in their home and garden.
- Offer to help them for an hour or so and ask what you could do to help them.
- Whatever you do, do it to the best of your ability so that the person is truly blessed by your work.
- Could you offer help on a regular basis as your family's mission or kindness project?

THURSDAY SNAPSHOT!

THE VERSE

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THE INTRODUCTION

Jesus wants everybody to be welcome and included in His kingdom of love. He doesn't want anyone to be excluded because of their disability, or because they can't see, hear, or move around easily.

THE DEVOTIONAL

God is happiest when we reach everyone. Nothing gives Him greater joy than bringing joy to lonely and hurting people whose needs are often forgotten. We are called to be extensions of His love.

THE PRAYER

Ask the Lord for confidence and trust that it is Him acting through you when you reach out to help people with disabilities.

THE CONVERSATION

Discuss as a family how everyone can train their minds to develop sympathy and empathy for people with disabilities.